China’s defeat and the measures needed to make the country strong again. The Statecraft School, represented by the scholar and palace adviser Wei Yuan (1794–1856) argued that it was the West’s advanced military technology, in particular its naval forces, which explained its ability to overwhelm Chinese defences. Wei Yuan formulated a plan for boosting China’s maritime capabilities by building ships, making weapons and learning the superior techniques of the ‘barbarians’.

The Self-Strengthening Movement (1861–95) which followed went further, and proposed not only the acquisition of modern armaments from the West but the study of Western languages and new subjects such as geography, mathematics and science. But this would be in addition to the study of Confucian classics. The objective was, as one of the proponents of the movement said, to ‘use the barbarians’ superior techniques to control the barbarians’. The objective of the reforms would be to retain the ‘Chinese essence’ while adopting practical techniques from the West. The important figures leading the movement were Confucian literati who had passed the civil service examination in the highest grade but were conscious of the need to reform in order to strengthen the empire.

One of the most important figures in this respect was Li Hongzhang (1823–1901), who promoted the opening of modern coal mines and the laying of railway lines in China. Li was also responsible for the setting up of the Beiyang Navy with imported vessels, and with some manufacturing and repair workshops. Other influential figures of this time were Zeng Guofan (1811–72) and Zuo Zongtang (1812–85). They acknowledged the Western challenge but asserted that China’s traditional value system and education could provide the answers. This was encapsulated in the slogan ‘*Zhong xue wei ti, xi xue wei yong* ’ – taking Chinese education as the mainstay but studying the West for practical use.

Not all Chinese scholars were convinced about this approach. Yan Fu (1854–1921) argued that adoption of Western technology would not strengthen the country unless the ideas and institutions underlying it were fully understood and adopted. Yan Fu considered Chinese ‘tradition’ to be an obstacle in China’s path to modernization. The old Confucian learning,